

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- 11 per cent increase in capex, translating to nearly Rs 11 lakh crore
- 20 million additional houses to be built in the next five years under PMAY-Grameen
- Three economic railway corridor programmes to be implemented—energy, mineral and cement corridors; port connectivity corridors; and high traffic density corridors
- 40,000 normal rail bogies will be converted to the Vande Bharat standards
- Rooftop solarisation will see 10 million households get 300 units of free power a month
- Greater adoption of e-buses for public transport networks
- Girls in the 9-14 age group will be vaccinated against cervical cancer
- A corpus of Rs 1 lakh crore to be set up with a 50-year interest-free loan to scale up research and innovation in sunrise domains

the age group of 9-14 years will be vaccinated against cervical cancer. Meanwhile, healthcare cover under the Ayushman Bharat scheme will be extended to all ASHA workers, anganwadi workers and helpers.

To scale up research and innovation in sunrise domains, a corpus of Rs 1 lakh crore will be set up with a 50-year interest-free loan, primarily for the private sector. Partha Chatterjee, the dean of academics and a professor in the Department of Economics at the Shiv Nadar University, notes that, as India endeavours to boost its semiconductor industry and high-tech manufacturing, this substantial financial support will empower private companies to significantly enhance their research and development divisions. In agriculture, to ensure faster growth of the sector, the Centre will further promote private and public investment in post-harvest activities, including aggregation, modern storage, efficient supply chains, primary and secondary processing and marketing and branding.

Overall, the interim budget reflected the Modi government's confidence in continuity.

***–with* Anilesh S. Mahajan & Sonal Khetarpal**

TELANGANA

REVANTH REDDY REVS AHEAD

By Amarnath K. Menon

Change and continuity were the two concerns the Congress had in Telangana as Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy took charge on December 7. The new CM faces three principal challenges—implementing the party's pre-poll promises, getting the state back on the fast track economically and ensuring the party wins at least half of the state's 17 Lok Sabha seats in the general election in May.

For any chief minister, this can be a daunting exercise. But Revanth, despite his lack of administrative experience, has started well. The Lok Sabha polls will be his first major test. Ministers have already been designated as party coordinators in the various constituencies. The Revanth administration's plan is to try and fulfil the pre-poll promises (the Six Guarantees or '6G'), and hope it becomes a vote 'influencer'. The entire administration was involved in the Praja Palana (People Friendly Governance) initiative from December 28 to January 6, covering 12,769 gram panchayats and 3,623 municipal wards and collecting a staggering 12.6 million applications from people. Of these, around 10.6 million were seeking the 6G benefits under various welfare heads while the remaining 2 million were seeking food security cards and other doles.

Through Praja Palana, the government hopes to take 'doorstep governance' a step further while also creating a comprehensive database of people's needs and grievances. The data from the applications will be available by January-end. The arduous